

RESEARCH

EU AI Act: Step-by-Step Compliance Roadmap

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CHAPTER 01

Executive Summary

CHAPTER 01

Executive Summary

Compliance is a **six-phase program** — **Govern** → **Inventory** → **Classify** → **Gap-Assess** → **Remediate** → **Conform** → **Operate** — sequenced so that *live* obligations are met first and *deferred* high-risk obligations are built toward before they crystallize [HIGH]. Two duties are already enforceable (Art. 5 prohibitions and Art. 4 literacy, both since 2 Feb 2025); the next hard deadline is **Article 50 transparency on 2 Aug 2026** (not deferred); high-risk obligations were pushed to **2 Dec 2027** (Annex III) and **2 Aug 2028** (Annex I) by the Digital Omnibus [HIGH]. The two failure modes that sink programs are **starting the Annex IV technical file late** (it is accumulated evidence, not a closing document) and **role misclassification** (fine-tuning + re-branding a model silently makes you a *provider* with the full obligation set) [HIGH]. SMEs get real relief — inverted penalty math, simplified microenterprise documentation, and priority sandbox access — but the substantive controls are not waived [MEDIUM].



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CHAPTER 02

Introduction

CHAPTER 02

Introduction

This is document 3 of the four-part EU AI Act Compliance Suite. Where [R-00154](#) enumerates the obligations and [R-00155](#) details the controls, companies still face the harder operational problem: not *what* must be done, but *in what order*. They need an ordered playbook — a sequenced program with owners, artifacts, and done-criteria — not just a list of duties. This research supplies that framing.

Why this research

Objectives

The primary question this research answers: **In what concrete, ordered sequence does a company go from "we don't know what AI we have" to "we are demonstrably EU AI Act compliant and staying that way?"** The objective is to convert the obligation and control inventories of the prior suite documents into an actionable, deadline-prioritized project plan that any organization can execute.

Scope

This document covers the end-to-end compliance roadmap as a single program. Obligations, controls, and the business case are treated as siblings feeding into one sequenced plan: the roadmap synthesizes the obligation set ([R-00154](#)) and the control set ([R-00155](#)) into phases with explicit owners, artifacts, and completion criteria, mapped against the post-Omnibus enforcement timeline.

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CHAPTER 03

Background & Context

CHAPTER 03

Background & Context

This is document 3 of the suite, synthesizing the obligations ([R-00154](#)) and controls ([R-00155](#)) into a sequenced project plan with owners, artifacts, and done-criteria. Rather than re-listing duties, it orders them into a program whose phases gate one another: governance precedes inventory, inventory precedes classification, classification precedes gap assessment, and remediation is sequenced by enforceability so that live obligations are met first while deferred high-risk obligations are built toward ahead of their crystallization.

The plan assumes the **post-Omnibus timeline** while flagging that the Digital Omnibus is not yet formally enacted (Council adoption expected ~29 June 2026). Under that timeline, Art. 5 prohibitions and Art. 4 literacy are live (since 2 Feb 2025), Article 50 transparency lands 2 Aug 2026, and high-risk obligations are deferred to 2 Dec 2027 (Annex III) and 2 Aug 2028 (Annex I). Where the Omnibus deferral fails to enact, 2 Aug 2026 remains the Annex III fallback scenario.

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CHAPTER 04

Methodology

CHAPTER 04

Methodology

This research is anchored to primary and official sources: **EUR-Lex** (the consolidated legal text), the **AI Act Explorer** (article-level navigation of the Act and its annexes), the European **Commission / AI Pact** materials (regulatory framework, governance, literacy Q&A, code of practice, draft classification guidelines), and the official **Compliance Checker** and AI Act Service Desk. Law-firm and practitioner analyses (Gibson Dunn, Covington, Timelex, LegalNodes, and others) supplement the primary text where operational sequencing or market practice is at issue.

Each finding carries a confidence marker on a three-point scale: **HIGH** (grounded in primary legal text or official guidance), **MEDIUM** (grounded in credible secondary analysis or reasonable synthesis), and **LOW** (speculative or weakly sourced). No LOW-confidence findings appear in this document.

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CHAPTER 05

Findings

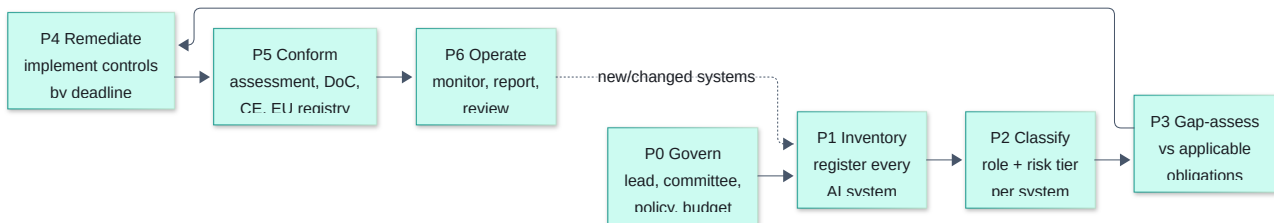
CHAPTER 05

Findings

Figure 1. The six-phase compliance lifecycle; P6 feeds back to P1 whenever the AI portfolio changes (source: synthesis of [implementation timeline](#) + Arts. 9–73).

F1 — The roadmap is six sequenced phases, each gating the next [HIGH]

Why: the phases are strictly ordered — you cannot classify what you haven't inventoried, or remediate what you haven't gap-assessed; this is the program's backbone.



F2 — Phase 0 Govern: name an owner, stand up a committee, publish a policy [HIGH]

Appoint an AI Governance Lead with a board reporting line (for SMEs, can combine with the DPO role), convene a cross-functional committee (Legal, IT/ML, HR, Product, Privacy), secure board budget, and publish an internal AI policy (scope, role-classification procedure, Art. 5 prohibitions, procurement due diligence, literacy commitment, incident paths). Optionally join the free [AI Pact](#). **Owner:** Governance Lead + Legal + C-suite. **Artifacts:** charter, appointment, budget, signed policy. **Done:** committee met, policy published, budget owned. *All quick wins (2–4 weeks); start now — Art. 4 is live* [HIGH].

F3 — Phase 1 Inventory: you cannot comply with what you cannot see [HIGH]

Apply the broad Art. 3(1) definition and run parallel discovery: IT asset/cloud/API sweep, business-unit interviews ("what helps you decide or predict?"), procurement review, and an explicit **shadow-AI check** for embedded SaaS features (Einstein, Copilot, recruiter filters) — which typically surface 30–50% more systems ([Intelance](#)). Capture per system: owner, status, vendor, role (provider/deployer/both), EU reach, data sensitivity, decision role, preliminary tier. Make the register a living artifact gated into the change-advisory process. **Done:** every production system listed with named owners and a provisional role [HIGH].

F4 — Phase 2 Classify: a seven-step test fixes role and risk tier [HIGH]

Why: classification gates every downstream obligation — getting the tier or the role wrong invalidates the whole compliance plan for that system.

Figure 2. The seven-step classification decision (a GPAI-model track runs in parallel: Art. 53/55 from 2 Aug 2025). Art. 6(3) exceptions still require EU-database registration and a documented rationale (source: [Art. 6](#), [Annex III](#), [Timelex 7-step test](#)).

Use the free [Compliance Checker](#). **Done:** every system has a confirmed tier + role with legal-reviewed rationale; all Art. 5 issues surfaced [HIGH].

F5 — Phase 3 Gap-assess: map current state to applicable obligations, prioritized by deadline [HIGH]

Build the obligation set per tier and role (provider high-risk → Arts. 9–17, 43, 47–49, 72–73; deployer → Art. 26; limited → Art. 50; everyone → Arts. 4 & 5), run structured per-system gap interviews, and produce a **Gap Register** (system | obligation | current state | gap | severity | effort | owner | deadline). Add a GDPR-intersection map (reuse DPIAs) and a FRIA triage (Art. 27 for public bodies and credit/insurance deployers) ([LegalNodes](#)). **Done:** every high/limited-risk system has a severity-rated gap assessment feeding Phase 4 [HIGH].

F6 — Phase 4 Remediate: implement controls in deadline order [HIGH]

The longest phase, sequenced by enforceability:

Tier	Deadline	Work
A	live (2 Feb 2025)	AI-literacy program (role-differentiated, keep records); prohibited-practice audit
B	2 Aug 2026	Art. 50 disclosures: chatbot "you're talking to AI", emotion/biometric notices, deepfake labels
C	2 Dec 2026	Machine-readable marking (C2PA) of pre-existing generative systems
D	2 Dec 2027	Full Annex III high-risk: risk mgmt (Art. 9), data governance (Art. 10), technical docs (Art. 11/Annex IV — start first, longest lead) , logging (Art. 12), instructions (Art. 13), human oversight (Art. 14), accuracy/robustness/security (Art. 15), QMS (Art. 17), PMM plan (Art. 72), FRIA (Art. 27), deployer controls (Art. 26)
E	2 Aug 2028	Annex I embedded systems via the product's conformity route + AI requirements

Start Tier D no later than **Q3 2026** for complex systems — high-risk compliance takes 6–18 months ([Witness.ai checklist](#), [AI Assurance Institute](#)). **Done:** Tiers A/B by Aug 2026, C by Dec 2026, D docs at 80%+ six months before Dec 2027 [HIGH].

F7 — Phase 5 Conform: assessment → DoC → CE → EU registry [HIGH]

Determine the route (Annex VI internal control for most; Annex VII notified body for biometric systems lacking full harmonized-standard coverage), compile the conformity file, issue the EU **Declaration of Conformity** (Art. 47), affix **CE marking** (Art. 48), and **register** in the EU database before market placement (Arts. 49/71) ([Art. 43](#), [DeepInspect](#)). Begin no later than Q1

2027 (Q3 2026 for complex/biometric systems, given notified-body queues). See the conformity flowchart in [R-00155](#) F6. **Done:** every high-risk system has a signed DoC, CE mark, and registration before its deadline [HIGH].

F8 — Phase 6 Operate: monitoring, incident reporting, change gates, horizon scanning [HIGH]

Run post-market monitoring (Art. 72) with deployer feedback loops; implement serious-incident detection and the **2/10/15-day** reporting chain (Art. 73) with a tested tabletop drill; refresh literacy annually; gate every change through a "substantial modification" review (which can reset conformity); and scan the regulatory horizon (annual Art. 5 review, four-yearly Annex III review, national laws like Italy's Law 132/2025) ([Art. 72](#), [Art. 73](#)). **Done:** active monitoring on all high-risk systems; inventory updated within 30 days of any change [HIGH].

F9 — Ownership is cross-functional; siloing it in Legal is a known failure mode [HIGH]

Why: the most common organizational failure is treating the Act as a Legal-only project; the RACI below makes the shared accountability explicit.

Activity	Gov. Lead	Legal/DPO	IT/Eng	Business	Data/ML	Notified Body	Board
P0 Policy & budget	A	C	C	I	I	–	A
P1 Inventory	A	C	R	R	C	–	I
P2 Classification	A	A	C	C	R	–	I
P3 Gap assessment	A	R	C	C	R	–	I
P4 Literacy/transparency	A	R	R	R	C	–	I
P4 High-risk controls	A	C	R	I	R	–	I
P5 Conformity/registration	A	A	C	I	C	R	I
P6 Monitoring/incidents	A	R	R	C	R	C	I

Figure 3. RACI ownership matrix (R=Responsible, A=Accountable, C=Consulted, I=Informed). Notified body engages only for Annex VII (biometric) conformity (source: synthesis; role split per [Art. 16](#) vs [Art. 26](#)).

F10 — SMEs get real relief, but not a pass [MEDIUM]

Inverted penalty math (the *lower* of cap or %), simplified microenterprise documentation (<10 staff AND <€2M turnover, Art. 62a), and **priority sandbox access** (Arts. 57–63; national sandboxes by 2 Aug 2027, incl. Spain's AESIA, France's CNIL/ARCEP) with fine immunity for good-faith participation ([Legalithm](#), [Art. 57](#)). 200+ European Digital Innovation Hubs offer free assessments. A company with only a chatbot can reach Phase 4B for well under €5k in staff time. **But** risk management, data governance, conformity, transparency, and monitoring are never waived [MEDIUM].

Phase → Artifacts → Deadline

Phase	Key artifacts	Articles	Deadline
0 Govern	Charter; AI policy; budget	4, 17	Immediate
1 Inventory	System register; role memo	3, 16	Immediate
2 Classify	Per-system rationale; exception docs	5, 6, Annex III	Immediate (Art. 5 live)
3 Gap-assess	Gap register; FRIA list; GDPR map	9–15, 26, 50	Immediate
4A	Training records; prohibition audit	4, 5	Live (2 Feb 2025)
4B	Art. 50 disclosures	50	2 Aug 2026
4C	C2PA marking	50(2)	2 Dec 2026
4D	Annex IV file; RMS; QMS; oversight	9–17, 72	Start Q3 2026 → 2 Dec 2027
4E	Product-sector conformity + AI	Annex I	2 Aug 2028
5 Conform	DoC; CE; EU registration	43, 47–49, 71	2 Dec 2027 / 2 Aug 2028
6 Operate	PMM reports; incident reports; review	72, 73, 112	Ongoing

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CHAPTER 06

Analysis / Discussion

CHAPTER 06

Analysis / Discussion

The defining property of this roadmap is that its phases *gate* one another: you cannot classify systems you have not inventoried, gap-assess against a tier you have not confirmed, or remediate a gap you have not yet scored. This dependency chain is why a list of obligations is insufficient — order is itself a compliance control. A program that runs phases out of sequence (for example, starting remediation before classification is legally reviewed) risks pouring effort into the wrong tier or the wrong role, and the seven-step test makes plain that a single misclassification invalidates the whole plan for that system. The two failure modes converge here: **role misclassification** (where fine-tuning and re-branding silently promotes a deployer into a full-obligation provider) and **late technical documentation** (where the Annex IV file is mistaken for a closing artifact rather than evidence accumulated across the entire remediation phase). Both are failures of sequencing, not of effort.

The second cross-cutting theme is **start-now-despite-deferral**. The Digital Omnibus pushed the heavy Annex III and Annex I obligations to 2027 and 2028, which invites the misreading that the program can wait. But the live duties (Art. 4 literacy and Art. 5 prohibitions) and the un-deferred 2 Aug 2026 Art. 50 transparency deadline already demand action, and the longest-lead high-risk artifacts — the technical file, the QMS, the conformity route through notified-body queues — require 6–18 months of build time, meaning Tier-D work must begin in Q3 2026 to land before Dec 2027. The deferral therefore changes the calendar, not the start date. The RACI matrix reinforces the same point from the organizational angle: siloing the Act in Legal is the most common structural failure, because the substantive work (inventory, controls, monitoring) lives in Engineering, Data/ML, and the business units. SME relief softens the penalty and documentation burden but waives none of these substantive controls — so even the smallest in-scope organization runs the same sequence, only cheaper.

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CHAPTER 07

Conclusion

CHAPTER 07

Conclusion

A company goes from "we don't know what AI we have" to "demonstrably compliant and staying that way" by running **six gated phases in strict order — Govern, Inventory, Classify, Gap-Assess, Remediate, Conform, Operate — with remediation sequenced by enforceability so live obligations are met first and deferred high-risk obligations are built toward before they crystallize.** That is the direct answer to the primary question: there is a concrete, ordered sequence, and it is this one.

The synthesis across the findings is that order is the binding constraint. Each phase produces the input the next phase consumes — the inventory feeds classification, classification feeds the gap register, the gap register feeds deadline-ordered remediation, and operation feeds back into inventory whenever the portfolio changes. The two program-killers (late technical documentation and role misclassification) are both sequencing failures, and the deferred 2027/2028 deadlines do not license delay because the longest-lead artifacts take 6–18 months and the live and 2 Aug 2026 duties are already due. The "so what" is straightforward: a company that names an owner, inventories and classifies now, and begins Tier-D documentation in Q3 2026 will meet every deadline on a defensible, evidence-backed footing; a company that waits for the deferred dates or treats compliance as a Legal-only closing exercise will not. The relief afforded to SMEs lowers the cost of running this sequence but never excuses skipping it.

CHAPTER 08

Recommendations (given June 2026)

CHAPTER 08

Recommendations (given June 2026)

1. **Within 30 days:** Phase 0 + start Phases 1–2; remediate Art. 4 literacy and run the Art. 5 audit (both already enforceable).
 2. **By 31 Jul 2026:** Finish the Art. 50 transparency gap assessment and ship disclosures — hard deadline, simple change, treat as P0 engineering.
 3. **By 31 Oct 2026:** Complete inventory + classification; begin high-risk gap assessment; implement watermarking for the Dec 2026 deadline.
 4. **Q1 2027+:** Execute Tier-D high-risk controls, **technical documentation first** (longest lead), parallelized per system.
 5. **Q2–Q3 2027:** Begin conformity assessment; engage notified bodies early for biometric systems.
 6. **Don't wait for harmonized standards** — they offer safe harbors, not new requirements; the legal text is already actionable.
 7. **Use free EU resources** (Compliance Checker, AI Act Explorer, Service Desk, Commission templates, AI Pact) to cut consulting spend.
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CHAPTER 09

Limitations

CHAPTER 09

Limitations

- **Digital Omnibus not yet enacted** (as of 24 Jun 2026) — deferred dates conditional on Council adoption + OJ publication; keep 2 Aug 2026 as the Annex III fallback scenario.
 - **Harmonized standards not OJ-published** — conformity routes for biometric systems may shift on publication.
 - **National variation** — competent authorities, sandboxes, and penalty regimes differ; some states add national AI laws.
 - **Commission guidance still evolving** — high-risk classification guidelines (draft May 2026), Art. 72 monitoring template (due Feb 2026) — cite final versions in compliance docs.
 - **Art. 62a microenterprise threshold** (<10 staff AND <€2M) is narrower than the general SME definition — most "SMEs" don't qualify for simplified documentation though they keep the penalty inversion.
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CHAPTER 10

Sources

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Sources

#	Title	Credibility	URL
1	AI Act Explorer — Implementation Timeline	High	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/implementation-timeline/
2	AI Act Explorer — Art. 5	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/5/
3	AI Act Explorer — Art. 6	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/6/
4	AI Act Explorer — Annex III	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/annex/3/
5	AI Act Explorer — Art. 9	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/9/
6	AI Act Explorer — Art. 10	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/10/
7	AI Act Explorer — Art. 14	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/14/
8	AI Act Explorer — Art. 16	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/16/
9	AI Act Explorer — Art. 26	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/26/
10	AI Act Explorer — Art. 27 (FRIA)	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/27/
11	AI Act Explorer — Art. 43	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/43/
12	AI Act Explorer — Art. 48	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/48/
13	AI Act Explorer — Art. 49	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/49/
14	AI Act Explorer — Art. 50	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/50/
15	AI Act Explorer — Art. 57 (Sandboxes)	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/57/
16	AI Act Explorer — Art. 71 (EU Database)	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/71/
17	AI Act Explorer — Art. 72	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/72/
18	AI Act Explorer — Art. 73	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/73/
19	AI Act Explorer — Art. 4	High (primary)	https://artificialintelligenceact.eu/article/4/
20	Gibson Dunn — Omnibus postponed deadlines	Medium-High (law firm)	https://www.gibsondunn.com/eu-ai-act-omnibus-agreement-postponed-high-risk-deadlines-and-other-key-changes/
21	Covington / Global Policy Watch — timeline relief	Medium-High (law firm)	https://www.globalpolicywatch.com/2026/06/eu-ai-act-update-timeline-relief-targeted-simplification-and-new-prohibitions-2/
22	Commission — AI Act regulatory framework	High (official)	https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/regulatory-framework-ai
23	Commission — AI Act governance & enforcement	High (official)	https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/ai-act-governance-and-enforcement
24	Commission — AI Literacy Q&A	High (official)	https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/faqs/ai-literacy-questions-answers
25	Commission — Code of Practice on AI-Generated Content	High (official)	https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/code-practice-ai-generated-content
26	Commission — draft high-risk classification guidelines	High (official draft)	https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/library/draft-commission-guidelines-classification-high-risk-ai-systems
27	Commission — AI Pact	High (official)	https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/ai-pact

28	EU AI Act Compliance Checker	High (official tool)	https://ai-act-service-desk.ec.europa.eu/en/eu-ai-act-compliance-checker
29	AI Act Service Desk — resources	High (official)	https://ai-act-service-desk.ec.europa.eu/en/resources
30	Timelex — 7 steps to classify high-risk	Medium-High (law firm)	https://www.timelex.eu/en/blog/7-steps-identify-if-your-ai-system-high-risk-under-ai-act
31	Legalithm — SME compliance guide	Medium	https://www.legalithm.com/en/blog/eu-ai-act-compliance-guide-startups-smes
32	Corporate Compliance Insights — role misclassification	Medium	https://www.corporatecomplianceinsights.com/most-overlooked-risk-eu-ai-act/
33	DeepInspect — conformity assessment guide	Medium	https://www.deepinspect.ai/blog/eu-ai-act-conformity-assessment
34	AI Assurance Institute — mandatory QMS	Medium	https://aiassurance.institute/articles/mandatory-quality-management-system.html
35	Intelance — AI inventory methodology	Medium	https://www.intelance.co.uk/eu-ai-act-system-inventory/
36	Witness.ai — compliance checklist 2026	Medium	https://witness.ai/blog/eu-ai-act-compliance-checklist-2026/
37	LegalNodes — EU AI Act 2026 updates	Medium-High	https://www.legalnodes.com/article/eu-ai-act-2026-updates-compliance-requirements-and-business-risks
38	eucrim — Guidelines on Prohibited AI Practices	High (academic)	https://eucrim.eu/news/guidelines-on-prohibited-ai-practices/